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Feminist AI: Feminist Perspectives on Artificial Intelligence (AI) in the Workplace

Artificial Intelligence-Driven Inequality: Gendered and Intersectional Experiences of Workplace Discrimination in Europe

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ABSTRACT

Artificial intelligence (AI) is increasingly reshaping critical areas such as hiring and workplace management, yet it risks systematically reproducing and amplifying existing inequalities, particularly regarding vulnerable groups. As addressing this urgent concern, we apply a feminist framework to examine gender differences in experiences of AI-driven discrimination among employees and job seekers. Using survey data from 4417 individuals across 28 European countries, we demonstrate how such discrimination is patterned along gendered lines. Our findings suggest that women, older individuals, non-White individuals, and those in non-permanent employment are, overall, more likely than other participants to perceive or experience negative discrimination from AI applications. This pattern also extends to individuals identifying as "other gender." Understanding intersecting inequalities and engaging feminist perspectives that question whose knowledge, values, and experiences are embedded in technological systems are essential. Only then can AI contribute to workplaces that are genuinely trustworthy. This, however, remains challenging given how ingrained inequality is in AI tools.

1 | Introduction

Artificial intelligence (AI) is increasingly shaping the workplace, with nearly 80% of business leaders viewing AI adoption as key for competitiveness (Work Trend Index Annual Report 2024). According to the report, this rapid uptake is driven not only by curiosity but also by pressure, as many lack the time or energy to finish their tasks as requested and turn to AI for assistance. However, this growing reliance also raises critical questions, as feminist scholars have long argued that technologies are not neutral. Technological domains have historically been constructed as masculine, imbued with assumptions of male rationality and technical competence (Toupin 2025; Young et al. 2023; Wajcman and Young 2023). AI systems are no exception. Often trained on historically biased data, they embed and reproduce gender power relations, reinforcing existing hierarchies rather than dismantling them (Gichoya et al. 2023; Njoto et al. 2024). Recruitment algorithms disproportionately favor men for high-paying roles (Loukides 2021), machine translation systems associate femininity with weakness and domestic roles and masculinity with strength and labor market participation (Sólmundsdóttir et al. 2022), and in-house recruitment tool actively disadvantage female candidates by mirroring male-

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dominated hiring patterns (Dastin 2018). These are not isolated failures but expressions of a systemic discriminatory pattern (Carter 2024; O'Connor and Liu 2024).

Crenshaw (1989, 2017) concept of intersectionality provides a framework for understanding how multiple dimensions of identity and power intersect to shape discrimination. Building on this perspective, Medda-Windischer and Crepaz (2025) argue that AI bias is not merely a technical problem, but a human-made social issue rooted in structural inequality. Similarly, Maatwk (2025) contends that AI-driven discrimination does not operate along gender lines alone as women's marginalization in these domains occurs at the intersections of social identity and power.

Crenshaw's (1989, 2017) concept of intersectionality is therefore essential for understanding how algorithmic systems may disproportionately disadvantage people positioned across multiple axes of inequality. Achieving fairer AI requires addressing these structural conditions, rather than relying solely on technical improvements to algorithms.

In response, feminist scholarship has sought to expose and challenge these dynamics, calling for more situated, intersectional, and context-sensitive approaches to AI design and use (Toupin 2025).

It is within this context that the present study is situated. Drawing on survey data from 4417 individuals, collected as part of the BIAS—Mitigating biases of AI in the labor market project, we examine how employees and job seekers across Europe perceive and experience AI-driven discrimination in the workplace, more specifically, in the process of managing employees from the time they apply until they leave the workplace. We aim to advance understanding of the link between AI use in the workplace and gender equality and how this manifests as intersectional discrimination across age, education, race, employment position, and residence.

The article proceeds by first outlining feminist perspectives that frame our analysis, before presenting our data and methods. We then analyze participants' perceptions and experiences of AI-driven discrimination across gender and intersecting social dimensions. We conclude by discussing implications for inclusive and context-sensitive AI governance in the workplace.

2 | Gender and Technology: A Feminist Framework

Feminist scholarship has long demonstrated that technology is not a neutral domain but a social one, shaped by and constitutive of power relations. From early critiques of women's exclusion from technological fields (Wajcman 2004; Johnson 2010) to cyberfeminist engagements with cyberspace (Cordes 2020; Rosser 2005), feminist scholars have consistently shown that technology encodes gendered assumptions about rationality, competence, and whose knowledge counts. The incorporation of intersectionality into "feminist technology studies" deepened this critique, establishing that gender does not operate in isolation but is co-constituted with race, class, and other structures of subordination and oppression (Benjamin 2019; Crenshaw 1989; Haraway 1988).

The proposition that AI systems encode gender bias is explained structurally by D'Ignazio and Klein (2023), who argue that biased outcomes in AI are not technical accidents but the result of deep epistemic and institutional imbalances within the data science industry itself. This means that the above-mentioned examples are symptoms of a system in which the production of AI knowledge is gendered. Without deliberate structural intervention, these systems risk institutionalizing sexism and other social inequalities into digital infrastructure (D'Ignazio and Klein 2023). Earlier, Benjamin (2019) similarly argued that algorithmic and automated decision systems reproduce racial inequalities while obscuring them through claims of neutrality. Consequently, understanding AI-driven discrimination requires a feminist-intersectional perspective, which reveals how inequality emerges through the intersections of multiple social identities and power relations rather than through single categories alone (Crenshaw 1989; D'Ignazio and Klein 2023; Maatwk 2025).

Yet feminist critiques of AI risk remaining within the very framework they seek to challenge. If AI is embedded in patriarchal epistemologies, approaches that seek greater inclusion or fairer design may inadvertently reproduce the power structures ingrained in the knowledge models they draw on. Lorde's (2004, 42) assertion that "the master's tools will never dismantle the master's house" captures this critique, highlighting the limitations of approaches that seek equality within existing technological infrastructures without addressing the power relations that underpin them. Birhane and Guest (2020) point out that these systems are built on foundations in which the Western, cisgender, white male perspective functions as the invisible norm, allowing hegemonic power to persist even in ostensibly neutral research and design. From this angle, addressing AI-driven discrimination demands not just correction of individual biases but a critical assessment of the historical and structural conditions under which AI is designed and deployed.

Feminist-intersectional frameworks allow us to analyze AI-driven discrimination in the workplace not as a correctable malfunction but as an expression of the structural and epistemic conditions under which these systems are built and normalized (Benjamin 2019; Fricker 2007). Nonetheless, many initiatives aiming at the design and use of so-called feminist AI (FAI) are grounded in techno-liberal frameworks that prioritize diversity and inclusion, while leaving intact the broader colonial, racialized, and gendered epistemologies that shape technological systems (D'Ignazio and Klein 2023; Toupin 2025). This study takes a different approach. We employ a feminist framework that view the design and use of AI systems throughout the employee lifecycle not just as a potential source of bias, but as a system that mirrors and perpetuates patriarchal values. This positioning has direct analytical consequences: it shifts the focus from whether AI produces unequal outcomes to how these outcomes are structurally produced, whose knowledge is embedded in these systems, and how discrimination is experienced across intersecting axes of inequality. Although our data is European, the logics of gender, hierarchy, classification, and exclusion identified are not geographically bound; rather they

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are constitutive of the technological systems operating across European workplaces.

In practice, we understand gender as a socially constructed, relational category, rather than a fixed, biological, or binary attribute. All gender categories are recognized as historically contingent and socially structured, intersecting with other axes of inequality such as age, education, and race. While our analysis primarily addresses differences between women and men, as the other gender category is too small for reliable statistical analysis, we treat these as analytical categories within a broader understanding of gender as multiple and ongoing, produced and maintained through repeated acts, norms, and performances (Butler 1990, 2006; Lorber 2018).

3 | Data and Methods

To explore workers' and job seekers' perspectives and experiences of AI-driven discrimination, from job application to workplace exit, we analyzed a unique cross-country survey data collected as part of the BIAS—Mitigating biases of AI in the labor market project.

The survey was conducted between May and November 2023 using the Qualtrics platform and gathered responses from individuals across 28 European countries. A variety of dissemination methods were employed, including the distribution of stickers, posters, and project-branded materials featuring a QR code linking to the survey, as well as recruitment via Prolific. After excluding incomplete responses, entries flagged by Qualtrics' fraud detection, and participants who did not provide initial consent, the final sample comprises 4417 valid responses. All respondents were aged 18 or older and had interacted with AI applications in the labor market, either as job applicants or employees.

The sample includes a higher proportion of younger and highly educated individuals, while remaining relatively balanced between women and men. The proportion of respondents identifying with other gender is too small to use in the models (see below). This composition reflects the recruitment methods used, such as Prolific, and may also be shaped by patterns of self-selection. Younger and more highly educated individuals are arguably more likely to engage with AI in the labor market, partly due to their greater confidence in using new technologies and their more optimistic views about the benefits of AI (European Commission 2025). While this age bias limits the generalizability of the results, the data enables us to interpret differences between women and men and gain deeper insight into the experiences of groups most likely to encounter AI systems in the workplace.

The survey comprised four modules:

1. Experience with AI. The first module investigates whether respondents have had prior experience with AI systems in the workplace, establishing a baseline for their familiarity with these technologies.
2. Experience of discrimination. The second module focuses on respondents who have interacted with AI systems, gathering specific insights into their experiences with discrimination.
3. Attitudes toward AI. The third module explores broader attitudes, mapping respondents' perspectives on the role and implications of AI systems in the workplace.
4. Demographic information. Finally, to contextualize gender, the fourth module captures demographic characteristics and diversity-related information about respondents.

Although the survey included 36 questions, this article focuses on four questions that asked the respondents to describe their positive and/or negative perceptions and experiences of discrimination related to AI applications. These questions are:

- *Do you believe that personal information could be used to negatively discriminate against you by AI applications?* (negative discrimination perception)
- *Do you believe that personal information could be used to positively discriminate in your favor by AI applications?* (positive discrimination perception)
- *Do you feel that you experienced negative discrimination?* (negative discrimination experience)
- *Do you feel that you experienced positive discrimination?* (positive discrimination experience)

In our analysis and discussion, we mainly focus on negative discrimination, as concerns about bias in AI-driven decision-making are primarily associated with the risk of exclusionary outcomes.

Analyzing both perceptions and experiences of AI discrimination captures complementary dimensions of how individuals relate to algorithmic decision-making. Perceptions reflect anticipated risks or benefits and shape trust in AI systems, willingness to use AI applications, and attitudes toward regulations. Instead, experienced discrimination captures whether individuals feel they have actually been treated unfairly or favorably by AI applications in practice.

These dimensions do not necessarily align. Individuals may perceive risks without having experienced discrimination or experience differential treatment without recognizing it as AI-driven. Examining both, therefore, helps identify gaps between anticipated and lived outcomes of using AI systems. Including both negative and positive discrimination further broadens the analysis by capturing not only perceived harm but also preferential treatment that may influence attitudes toward AI.

Our approach to analyzing the four questions statistically is to use models that estimate the probability of a respondent reporting positive and/or negative perceptions and experiences of discrimination based on gender and other sociodemographic information. Each of the key questions, our dependent variables, allowed for three possible responses: “No” (0), “I am not sure” (1), and “Yes” (2). Since these responses are categorical and have a clear ordinal structure, we employ an ordinal logistic regression model (McKelvey and Zavoina 1975), where the dependent variable can take values 0, 1, or 2. This modeling approach allows us to assess how various sociodemographic predictors are associated with an increased or decreased likelihood of perceiving or experiencing AI-driven discrimination, while accounting for the inherent ordering of the response categories.

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In our models, the sociodemographic predictors include gender (male, female, and other gender), age cohort (18–28, 29–39, 40–50, and over 50), race (white, non-white), educational attainment (tertiary education vs. all other levels), and employment status (permanent vs. non-permanent employees). As the survey does not include a direct measure of socioeconomic status (SES), educational attainment may serve as a proxy for SES, as is common in the literature, because it is strongly associated with occupational position and economic resources (e.g., Khalatbari-Soltani et al. 2022). We also control for respondents' country of residence to account for potential country-specific differences that may influence perceptions or experiences with AI. This is implemented through country fixed effects, by including a dummy variable for each country in the model. These fixed effects help control for unobserved structural, institutional, or cultural factors, such as national labor market characteristics, regulatory environments, or digital adoption levels, that could systematically affect responses across countries. Furthermore, we incorporate a broader societal variable by including the Global Gender Gap Index (GGGI),[1] classifying countries as either above or below the sample median. We propose that the overall level of gender equality in each country may influence how women and men perceive and report AI-related discrimination.

We believe that differences in attitudes between women and men toward potential and experienced discrimination stemming from AI is smaller in countries with higher gender equality compared to those with lower gender equality.

We selected this set of explanatory variables based on their theoretical relevance and interpretability, as our primary goal is to understand the factors associated with individuals reporting discrimination by AI in the workplace.

As already mentioned, this article primarily compares women and men, as the other gender category is too small for reliable statistical analysis. However, the survey included the categories women, men, and other gender, reflecting our adoption of a non-binary understanding of gender. These categories are treated as socially constructed and partly fluid rather than fixed representations of gender. The responses presented here reflect participant's self-identification at the time of completing the survey. As previously detailed, our analysis takes an intersectional perspective, interpreting gender in relation to other social dimensions, including education, age, and race.

4 | Findings

This section presents the main findings, outlining response patterns on AI-driven discrimination and statistical models, showing how gender and other sociodemographic factors influence their perceived or experienced likelihood.

Table 1 shows the distribution of the sociodemographic factors used to predict key outcomes.

More than half of respondents (54%) are aged between 18 and 28, and nearly three-quarters (73%) report having completed tertiary education. Gender representation is balanced, with 49% self-identifying as male and 48% as female, while 3% identify with another gender. In terms of racial background, the majority of participants identify as White (84%), while 16% identify as non-White. Employment status is evenly split between permanent and non-permanent employees. The largest national groups are coming from Portugal (21.3%) and Poland (18.4%). Moreover, most participants (63.6%) work in European countries scoring above the median on the Global Gender Gap Index (GGGI), reflecting a diverse range of institutional contexts regarding gender equality. These characteristics provide a strong basis for investigating perceptions of AI-driven discrimination in the workplace across different sociodemographic and national contexts in Europe. Before exploring the statistical models, we first show how respondents reported their perceptions and experiences of AI-driven discrimination.

The responses to the four key questions on perceptions and experiences of discrimination in AI for the workplace are distributed as follows (Table 2).

As shown in Table 2, 37% of men and 44% of women believed that personal information could be used to negatively discriminate against them by AI applications compared with 61% of other gender. Between 26% and 28% were unsure. Reported experiences of such discrimination were lower, affecting 6% of men, 9% of women, and 20% of other gender; however, uncertainty remained high (26% of men, 29% of women, and 43% of other gender). Fewer participants reported positive discrimination perception and experience. Overall, individuals identifying as other gender are more likely to perceive and experience AI-related discrimination than women and men. However, as this group represents only 3% of the sample, it was excluded from the statistical models in the following section due to an insufficient sample size for reliable estimation.

Descriptive sociodemographic characteristics for this subgroup are reported in Table A1. Compared with the full sample, respondents identifying outside the gender binary present distinct demographic shifts. This group is notably younger (61% aged 18–28 compared with 54% in the full sample) and more racially diverse, with 23% identifying as non-White (vs. 16% overall). While 73% of the full sample holds a tertiary degree, this figure is lower among the subgroup (63%). Most notably, this group faces higher labor instability; 60% hold non-permanent positions, whereas the general sample is evenly split between permanent and non-permanent employment. Geographically, the largest national subgroups are located in Poland (21%) and Portugal (14%), and 62% reside in countries scoring above the median on the Global Gender Gap Index.

To further explore the relationship between perception and experience at the individual level, we examined contingency tables linking these two dimensions (Table 3). While our cross-sectional data do not allow us to identify temporal changes in perception after AI use, the tables provide insight into how perceptions and experiences co-occur for each respondent.

Table 3 reports row percentages for negative (Panel A) and positive (Panel B) discrimination. The results indicate that individuals who perceive a risk of discrimination are more likely

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TABLE 1 | Distribution of responses for sociodemographic factors.

Sociodemographic factor	*n*	%
Age		
18–28	2379	54
29–39	1335	30
40–50	479	11
> 50	224	5
Total	4417	100
Gender		
Male	2170	49
Female	2101	48
Other gender	146	3
Total	4417	100
Race		
White	3569	84
Non-White	701	16
Total	4270	100
Education		
Tertiary education	3148	73
Rest of educational levels	1157	27
Total	4305	100
Employment status		
Permanent employee	2222	50
Non-permanent employee	2195	50
Total	4417	100
Global Gender Gap Index (GGGI)		
Above the median (Belgium, Denmark, Finland, France, Germany, Iceland, Ireland, Lithuania, Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, Spain, Sweden, and Switzerland)	2809	64
Below the median (Austria, Bulgaria, Croatia, Czech Republic, Estonia, Greece, Italy, Luxembourg, Malta, Poland, Romania, Slovakia, Slovenia, and Turkey)	1608	36
Total	4417	100
Country of residence		
Portugal	940	21
Poland	814	18
Germany	526	12
Spain	369	8
Netherlands	256	6
Greece	249	6
France	242	6
Italy	164	4
Ireland	91	2
Austria	87	2
Belgium	84	2
Estonia	81	2
Turkey	79	2

(Continues)

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TABLE 1 | (Continued)

Sociodemographic factor	*n*	%
Sweden	75	2
Slovenia	66	1
Switzerland	55	1
Norway	53	1
Finland	50	1
Czech Republic	46	1
Other European countries (Iceland, Denmark, Croatia, Slovakia, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malta, Romania, and Bulgaria)	90	2
Total	4417	100

Note: This table displays the survey response distribution across categories for each sociodemographic factor included as predictors in the statistical models. Frequencies (*n*) and percentages (%) are shown for all analytical subgroups.

TABLE 2 | Responses to key questions including perceptions and experiences of discrimination of AI in the workplace.

	Men		Women		Other gender		Total	
Question	***n***	**%**	***n***	**%**	***n***	**%**	***N***	**%**
Negative discrimination perception								
Yes	811	37	914	44	89	61	1814	41
No	772	36	584	28	19	13	1375	31
I am not sure	587	27	603	29	38	26	1228	28
Total	2170	100	2101	100	146	100	4417	100
Positive discrimination perception								
Yes	610	28	590	28	54	37	1254	28
No	561	26	494	24	27	18	1082	24
I am not sure	999	46	1012	48	64	44	2075	47
Total	2170	100	2096	100	145	100	4411	100
Negative discrimination experience								
Yes	136	6	182	9	29	20	347	8
No	1473	68	1313	62	54	37	2840	64
I am not sure	561	26	606	29	63	43	1230	28
Total	2170	100	2101	100	146	100	4417	100
Positive discrimination experience								
Yes	108	5	119	6	14	10	241	5
No	1382	64	1292	61	68	47	2742	62
I am not sure	680	31	690	33	64	44	1434	32
Total	2170	100	2101	100	146	100	4417	100

Note: This table presents gender-stratified survey responses to the four key questions assessing both positive and negative perceptions and experiences of discrimination associated with AI use in the workplace. Percentages reflect proportions within each gender category.

to report having experienced it. For instance, 15% of respondents perceiving negative discrimination report an actual experience, compared with only 2% among those who do not perceive such a risk. A similar pattern is observed for positive discrimination, with 12% of those perceiving positive discrimination reporting corresponding experiences. Nevertheless, a substantial share of individuals who perceive discrimination report no direct experience (49% for negative and 54% for positive discrimination), suggesting that perceptions often reflect anticipatory concerns rather than lived experience.

These descriptive tables provide an individual-level perspective on how perception and experience relate, highlighting that while there is an association, perception does not always correspond directly to personal experience.

4.1 | Perceptions and Experiences of Discrimination: Statistical Models

While the descriptive results offer an important overview, they do not capture the combined effects of multiple factors. To better understand this, we estimated four ordinal logistic regression models (one for each key question).

Table 4 shows the estimated coefficients (odds ratios) for the sociodemographic factors across the four ordinal logistic regression models. Positive coefficients indicate higher odds of responding in higher-ordinal categories, while negative values suggest the opposite. Models 1, 2, 3, and 4 correspond to the questions on negative discrimination perception, positive discrimination perception, negative discrimination experience, and positive discrimination experience, respectively.

4.1.1 | *Model 1: Negative Discrimination Perception*

We first examine whether respondents believe that AI systems could be used to disadvantage them based on personal information. Table 4 shows that:

- Women are significantly more likely than men to believe that AI applications could be used to discriminate against them.
- The age group 29–39 report higher perceptions of potential discrimination than younger respondents (aged 18–28).
- White respondents are significantly less likely to perceive a risk of discrimination compared to non-White respondents.
- Higher educational attainment is associated with greater concerns about negative discrimination.
- Non-permanent employees show higher perceived risks. A similar (though statistically non-significant) trend is

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TABLE 3 | Relationship between perceived and experienced discrimination.

Panel A: Negative discrimination				
Perceived negative discrimination	**Experienced: No (%)**	**Experienced: Not sure (%)**	**Experienced: Yes (%)**	**Total (%)**
No	90	8	2	100
I am not sure	58	38	4	100
Yes	49	36	15	100
Panel B: Positive discrimination				
Perceived positive discrimination	**Experienced: No (%)**	**Experienced: Not sure (%)**	**Experienced: Yes (%)**	**Total (%)**
No	85	13	2	100
I am not sure	55	41	4	100
Yes	54	35	12	100

Note: Entries report row percentages. Rows correspond to perceived discrimination and columns to experienced discrimination.

observed among respondents in countries with higher gender equality, as measured by the GGGI.

The heightened perceptions of potential discrimination among women and non-White individuals suggest that AI is not universally experienced as neutral or fair. Greater concerns among highly educated respondents suggest that awareness of systemic bias grows with education. Similarly, non-permanent workers' heightened concern reflects a precarity effect: those with less job security are more sensitive to any tool that might influence employment outcomes.

4.1.2 | *Model 2: Positive Discrimination Perception*

Model 2 focuses on whether respondents believe that AI systems could be used to advantage them. This model allows us to explore whether factors associated with optimism about AI differ from those linked to concerns about bias. The results show that:

- Age differences are significant, with individuals aged 29–39 more likely to perceive positive discrimination, while those over 40 perceive it less, compared to younger respondents (aged 18–28).
- No statistically significant gender differences emerged, though the trend suggests women are slightly more likely to perceive positive bias.
- While racial background did not reach statistical significance, the trend suggests that White respondents are slightly less likely to perceive positive bias than non-White respondents.
- Education and country-level gender equality were moderately associated with perceptions of positive discrimination.

This model reflects ambivalence: while some individuals imagine AI could favor them, this belief is much less widespread. Perceptions of positive discrimination are not strongly gendered, which suggests that the idea of being "favored by AI" is seen as unpredictable and context dependent.

4.1.3 | *Model 3: Negative Discrimination Experience*

Moving from perceptions to lived experiences, Model 3 examines whether respondents feel they have personally been disadvantaged by AI systems in workplace contexts. The results show that:

- Women are significantly more likely than men to report personal experiences of negative discrimination via AI systems.
- Respondents over 29 are significantly more likely to report negative discrimination experiences.
- White respondents are significantly less likely to report personal experiences of negative discrimination compared to non-White respondents.
- Non-permanent employees report higher experiences of discrimination than permanent employees.

Here, perceptions become lived realities: women, precarious workers, non-White respondents, and older employees feel the system working against them. Non-permanent workers' higher reports of discrimination show how employment instability magnifies vulnerability to AI-bias.

4.1.4 | *Model 4: Positive Discrimination Experience*

Finally, Model 4 investigates reports of positive discrimination on whether respondents feel they have personally benefited from AI systems. This analysis helps us understand who perceives AI as potentially opening doors rather than reinforcing barriers. The results are:

- Respondents in the middle-age groups (29–39 and 40–50 combined) are more likely to report experiences of positive discrimination.
- Gender differences are statistically significant but less pronounced than in the case of negative discrimination experiences. Women report slightly higher levels of positive discrimination.
- Racial background is statistically significant, with non-White respondents being more likely to report experiences of positive discrimination.
- Non-permanent employees report higher levels of positive discrimination compared to permanent employees.
- Respondents with higher education and those living in high-GGGI countries show a tendency to report more experiences of positive discrimination, although these effects are not statistically significant.

Positive discrimination through AI is experienced narrowly and tends to favor already privileged subgroups that include highly educated, securely employed individuals. Rather than correcting

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TABLE 4 | Ordinal logistic regression models estimation results.

Dependent variable	Model 1 Negative discrimination perception	Model 2 Positive discrimination perception	Model 3 Negative discrimination experience	Model 4 Positive discrimination experience
	(0: No, 1: I am not sure, 2: Yes)			
Age (reference category: 18–28)				
29–39	1.346***	1.139*	1.651***	1.353***
	(4.149)	(1.799)	(6.208)	(3.836)
40–50	1.14	0.699***	1.998***	1.353***
	(1.29)	(−3.444)	(6.101)	(2.692)
> 50	1.094	0.66***	2.103***	1.046
	(0.632)	(−2.941)	(4.802)	(0.284)
Gender (reference category: Male)				
Female	1.361***	1.044	1.35***	1.148**
	(5.099)	(0.701)	(4.366)	(2.057)
Race (reference category: Non-White)				
White	0.724***	0.935	0.597***	0.669***
	(−3.617)	(−0.763)	(−5.362)	(−4.199)
Education (reference category: Rest of educational levels)				
Tertiary education	1.07	1.08	1.057	1.11
	(0.952)	(1.079)	(0.69)	(1.316)
Employment status (reference category: Non-permanent employee)				
Permanent employee	0.873**	1.032	0.698***	0.857**
	(−2.148)	(0.489)	(−4.963)	(−2.185)
Global Gender Gap Index (reference category: Above the median)				
Below the median	0.748	0.376**	0.799	0.861
	(−0.638)	(−2.013)	(−0.425)	(−0.286)
Country you work in[a]				
Cut 1	0.539***	0.389***	2.533***	2.284***
	(−4.987)	(−7.586)	(6.583)	(5.965)
Cut 2	1.787***	3.19***	18.488***	24.995***
	(4.678)	(9.275)	(19.348)	(21.136)
Observations	4056	4051	4056	4056
Pseudo R^2	0.023	0.016	0.038	0.023

Note: This table reports estimation results from the four ordinal logistic regression models. The dependent variables are ordinal categorical measures with three response levels (0: No, 1: I am not sure, 2: Yes). Coefficients are expressed as odds ratios, where values above 1 indicate a higher likelihood of responding in a higher category (i.e., greater perception or experience of discrimination) compared to all lower categories combined, and values below 1 indicate a lower likelihood. Absolute *t*-statistics are shown in parentheses, with significance levels denoted by asterisks. Categorical predictors are interpreted relative to their reference categories.

[a]Country fixed effects are omitted due to space constraints.

***$p < 0.01$.

**$p < 0.05$.

*$p < 0.1$.

deep inequalities, AI systems seem more likely to offer minor advantages to those already advantaged, reproducing elite favoritism. This suggests that without deliberate interventions, AI tools will quietly entrench existing hierarchies, not disrupt them.

4.1.5 | *Patterns Across Baseline Models*

Taken together, the baseline models reveal some important patterns. First, perceptions and experiences of positive discrimination (Models 2 and 4) are more difficult to explain statistically than negative discrimination outcomes, as indicated by the lower pseudo-R^2 values.

Gender plays a substantial role in perceptions and experiences of negative discrimination (Models 1 and 3), but its influence appears weaker in the case of positive discrimination (Models 2 and 4).

In general, being older, being a woman, non-White, and having a higher level of education (education, although not significant in several models, consistently shows a positive sign) increases

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the probability of perceiving or experiencing discrimination by AI applications. These patterns highlight the complex social layering of trust and vulnerability in AI-mediated environments and motivate a deeper exploration of how gender interacts with other key factors, to which we now turn.

4.2 | Exploring Gender Differences Further: Interaction Models

While the baseline models provide valuable insights, some relationships, particularly those involving gender, warranted further exploration. In several cases, gender alone did not emerge as a significant predictor, yet prior research and theoretical expectations suggest that gender may interact with other factors. To explore these possibilities, we conducted additional interaction analyses.

In these interaction models, we assessed whether the effect of age, race, education, employment status, and national gender equality (GGGI) differs between women and men. Specifically, we reran Model 1–4, adding interaction terms one by one between gender and each variable of interest.

Figure 1 graphically illustrates how the predicted probability of perceiving or experiencing AI-related discrimination varies by gender and context. Table 5 complements this by reporting the marginal differences between women and men for each category and model. These marginal effects allow us to assess whether the gender differences observed in Figure 1 are statistically significant. Positive values in the marginal effects reported in the table indicate that women are more likely than men to perceive or experience discrimination in that category, while negative values suggest the opposite. Statistically significant differences are marked accordingly.

4.2.1 | Gender Differences in Negative Discrimination Perception (Model 1)

Marginal effects reveal that women are more likely than men to perceive negative discrimination across all age groups except those over 50, where differences are insignificant. This gender gap persists across education and employment status and is wider among individuals with lower education. Furthermore, the gender gap remains constant across racial backgrounds, with women being more likely than men to perceive negative discrimination among both White and non-White respondents. Women consistently report higher perceptions of discrimination in all national context compared to men, both in countries above and below the median in the Global Gender Gap Index (GGGI). However, the gender gap is wider among women residing in countries below the GGGI median, suggesting that national-level gender inequality amplifies perceived risks of discrimination.

4.2.2 | Gender Differences in Positive Discrimination Perception (Model 2)

Overall, gender differences in perceived positive discrimination are minimal. Furthermore, this gender gap remains negligible and statistically insignificant across racial backgrounds. However, women over 50 show slightly higher likelihood than men, and among permanent employees, women are more likely than men to perceive positive discrimination, while no significant gender differences emerge among non-permanent employees.

4.2.3 | Gender Differences in Negative Discrimination Experience (Model 3)

Marginal effects indicate that women consistently report a higher probability of experiencing negative discrimination than men across most categories. Gender differences are evident across all age groups, except among respondents over 50. Regarding racial background, the gender gap is significant for both groups, with women being 2 percentage points more likely than men to report such experiences among White respondents and 3 percentage points more likely among non-White respondents.

Among the highly educated, women are more likely than men to report negative discrimination, whereas no significant gender differences are observed at lower educational levels. The gap is also greater among non-permanent employees, highlighting the intersection of gender and employment precarity.

Across both high- and low-GGGI countries, women remain more likely than men to experience negative discrimination, indicating that different gender experiences of bias persist, regardless of national equality contexts.

4.2.4 | Gender Differences in Positive Discrimination Experience (Model 4)

Overall, gender differences in experiencing positive discrimination are less pronounced compared to other models. Across most age groups, differences are insignificant, although women aged 29–39 report slightly higher rates than men. Marginal effects show a small but statistically significant gender gap across racial backgrounds, where both White and non-White women are slightly more likely than men to report such experiences. Among the highly educated, women are more likely than men to report positive discrimination, with no significant differences at lower educational levels. The same pattern appears among permanent employees but not among non-permanent ones where no significant gender differences are observed. Finally, women in countries above the GGGI median are slightly more likely than men to report positive discrimination, while no gap appears below the median in the GGGI.

4.2.5 | Summary of Interaction Analysis

The interaction analyses reveal important nuances in how gender (being a woman or a man) associates with perceptions and experiences of AI-driven discrimination. Consistent gender gaps emerge most clearly in negative discrimination, both perceived and experienced, and models 1 and 3 show consistent gender differences across all variables. Women have a higher probability of perceiving or experiencing negative discrimination by AI applications than men, particularly among non-White respondents, those with lower educational levels, non-permanent workers, and individuals living in countries with lower gender equality. These findings highlight how systemic

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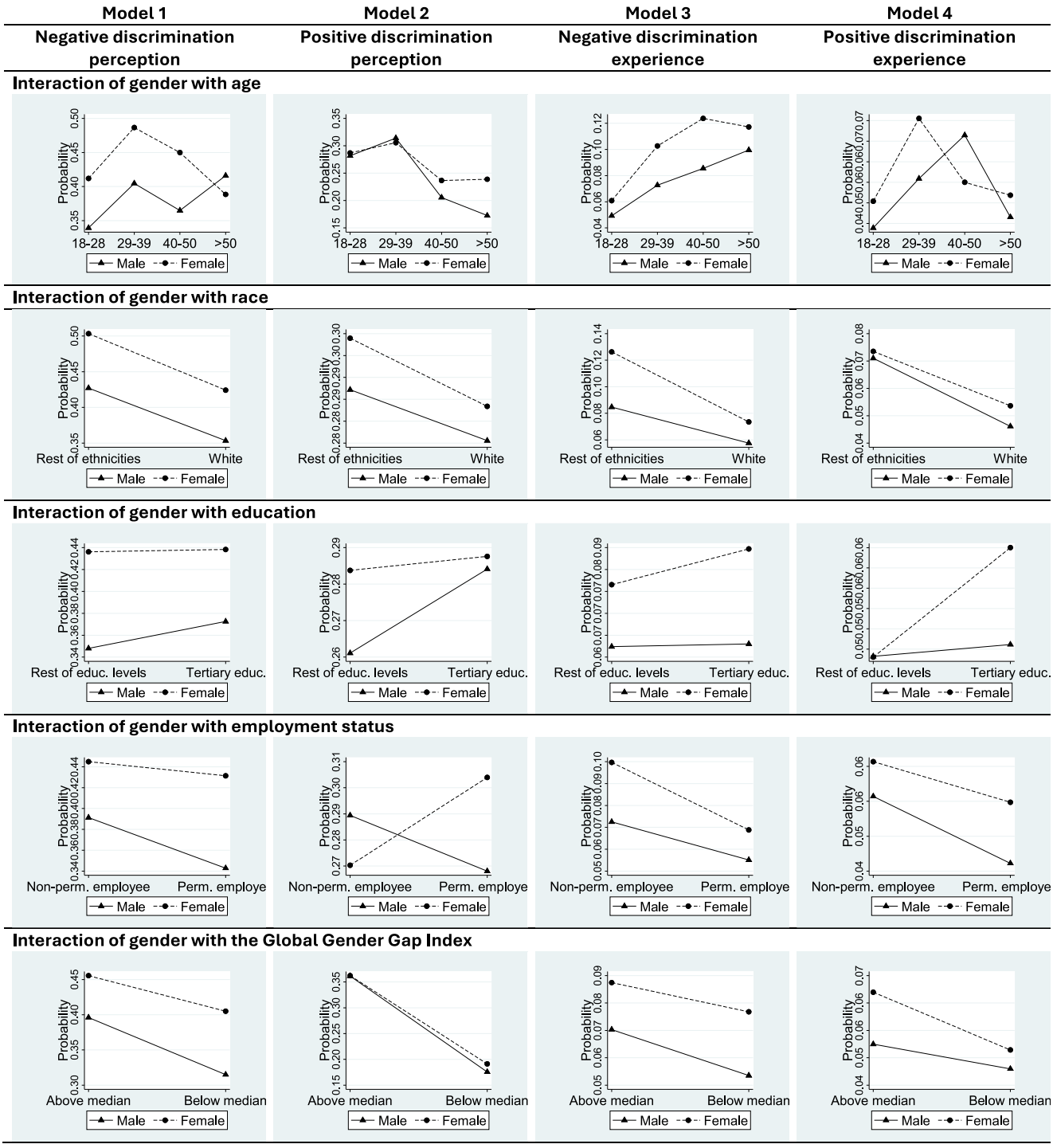


FIGURE 1 | Predicted probabilities of reporting AI-related discrimination: gender differences across sociodemographic groups. This figure displays the predicted probabilities of answering "YES" to each of the four key questions, comparing women and men across categories of age, race, education, employment status, and national gender equality (GGGI). These probabilities are derived from a series of interaction models. To estimate them, each of the four ordinal logistic regression models from Table 4 was rerun four times, each time including a single interaction between gender and one of the five explanatory variables—resulting in a total of 20 models.

inequalities are associated with experiences with AI, magnifying existing social vulnerabilities.

In contrast, models 2 and 4 (positive discrimination) reveal weaker, asymmetric patterns. Highly educated women in permanent employment and in countries with higher gender parity report higher perception and experience of positive discrimination. However, these effects are relatively modest and tend to be limited to more privileged groups, rather than signaling widespread corrective bias in favor of women.

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TABLE 5 | Marginal gender differences in reporting AI-related discrimination across sociodemographic groups.

	Difference between females and males			
Interaction variable	**Model 1**	**Model 2**	**Model 3**	**Model 4**
Age				
18–28 years old	0.07***	0.01	0.01**	0.01
	(3.91)	(0.31)	(2.32)	(1.57)
29–39 years old	0.08***	−0.01	0.03***	0.01**
	(3.16)	(−0.37)	(3.17)	(2.10)
40–50 years old	0.09**	0.03	0.04**	−0.01
	(2.01)	(0.99)	(2.08)	(−1.05)
> 50 years old	−0.03	0.07	0.02	0.01
	(−0.44)	(1.57)	(0.65)	(0.38)
Race				
White	0.07***	0.01	0.02***	0.01**
	(5.11)	(0.70)	(4.29)	(2.06)
Non-White	0.07***	0.01	0.03***	0.01
	(5.12)	(0.70)	(4.16)	(2.04)**
Education				
Tertiary education	0.07***	0.00	0.02***	0.01**
	(4.06)	(0.25)	(4.08)	(2.38)
Rest of educational levels	0.09***	0.02	0.01	0.00
	(3.23)	(0.97)	(1.63)	(−0.01)
Employment status				
Permanent employee	0.09***	0.04**	0.01**	0.01*
	(4.49)	(2.11)	(2.44)	(1.93)
Non-permanent employee	0.05***	−0.02	0.03***	0.00
	(2.69)	(−1.13)	(3.72)	(0.98)
Global Gender Gap Index				
Above the median	0.06***	0.00	0.02**	0.01*
	(3.33)	(0.05)	(2.52)	(1.93)
Below the median	0.09***	0.02	0.02***	0.00
	(3.90)	(1.08)	(2.58)	(0.68)

Note: This table reports the marginal differences between women and men derived from a series of interaction models. Coefficients represent the marginal difference in the predicted probability of answering "YES" to the key questions between females and males, conditional on the category of the interacted variable. Positive values indicate that women are more likely than men to report discrimination in that category; negative values indicate the opposite. Absolute *t*-statistics are shown in parentheses, with significance levels denoted by asterisks.

***$p < 0.01$.

**$p < 0.05$.

*$p < 0.1$.

Overall, the results suggest that AI systems are far from being neutral, but interact with, and often amplify, existing social inequalities, reinforcing rather than reducing entrenched existing marginalization.

5 | Discussion

This article examined how employees and job seekers in Europe perceive and experience AI-driven discrimination in the workplace, and how this reflects intersectional gender inequalities. By distinguishing between perceived and experienced discrimination, we show that concerns extend beyond direct experience. Perceptions alone may shape trust in AI systems and attitudes toward their use regardless of whether discrimination has occurred, a finding that is theoretically significant, as we discuss below.

5.1 | Risk of Inequality Through AI

The findings indicate that AI-driven discrimination is not merely a technical problem amenable to technical solutions, but a structural and epistemic condition. Being a woman, being older, non-White, and in non-permanent jobs increases in general the probability of perceiving or experiencing discrimination by AI applications. This pattern is consistent with a feminist-intersectional reading of AI. Rather than isolated incidents of bias, what emerges is a structural picture in which AI systems reflect and amplify intersecting inequalities.

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A particularly theoretically significant finding is the gap between perception and experience, with many respondents perceiving a risk of discrimination without having directly experienced it. Rather than treating this as a methodological limitation, a feminist-intersectional framework interprets it as substantively meaningful, reflecting the structural and epistemic inequalities embedded in the development and normalization of AI systems (Benjamin 2019; Fricker 2007). Precisely, the capacity to perceive bias before experiencing should not be regarded as noise; it reflects an embodied, socially positioned awareness of how technological systems have operated against certain groups over time. This connects to Fricker's (2007) concept of epistemic injustice, highlighting how lived experience of marginalization can sharpen awareness. Perceptions of AI discrimination are, therefore, not merely subjective impressions but socially structured signals of structural risk.

Findings on gender and race reinforce this picture. White respondents are consistently less likely to perceive or experience negative discrimination, while the gender gap holds across both White and non-White respondents, with non-White women showing marginally higher rates of negative discrimination experience. This is precisely what Benjamin (2019) and Birhane and Guest (2020) would predict: AI systems built on knowledge foundations that normalize whiteness do not merely fail to correct racial hierarchies, they encode and reproduce them. Crenshaw's (1989) concept of intersectionality further explains why these processes cannot be understood through gender and race alone, but through their interconnected effects. In this light, we argue that the intersection of gender and race in our data is not incidental but structural, reflecting that AI systems inherit the racial as well as patriarchal hierarchies embedded in the conditions of their production.

The findings related to education and the GGGI call for particular attention as they complicate the expected link between marginalization and AI-related discrimination. Women with higher education and those in countries with higher Global Gender Gap Index (GGGI) scores are more likely to perceive and experience AI as discriminatory. While the data does not provide specific reasons for this trend, it may indicate greater social awareness and discursive openness regarding gender and technology among individuals with higher levels of education and in more gender-equal societies. AI systems are predominantly developed in Western, high-GGGI contexts and embed the epistemological assumptions of those contexts, including meritocratic and technocratic logics that present algorithmic decision-making as objective and impartial (D'Ignazio and Klein 2023). Women in these settings may be more attuned to the gap between that promise and their lived experience, precisely because gender equality discourse has made that gap nameable. In lower-GGGI contexts, where AI may be newer or less embedded in employment decision-making, it may be perceived as an improvement on more overtly discriminatory human judgment, not because the systems are fairer, but because the baseline of comparison is different. However, this remains a hypothesis our data cannot confirm, but it points to an important direction for future research.

The findings are of particular concern, as the Work Trend Index Annual Report (2024) shows that HR managers are under increasing pressure to adopt AI-driven solutions to save time and create efficiencies, sometimes without fully understanding the limitations and embedded biases of these technologies. D'Ignazio and Klein (2023) caution that when development teams, which are still predominantly composed of white men, fail to examine their own positions, they risk embedding not only gender bias but broader intersectional and colonial hierarchies into digital infrastructures. Such "epistemic blindness" (Fricker 2007) reveals whose knowledge is recognized as legitimate and whose is marginalized, thereby reproducing long-standing systems of exclusion (Birhane and Guest 2020). Furthermore, HR professionals' reliance on supposedly neutral systems reinforces discrimination by normalizing and embedding historically constructed inequalities along the lines of gender, race, and other intersectional axes in algorithmic decision-making.

These patterns align with Maatwk's (2025) observation that inequality is both gendered and context-specific, and with Wajcman's (2004) argument that women develop a situated awareness of technological systems shaped by masculine and Western epistemologies. Taken together, they confirm that AI-driven discrimination in the workplace is not a technical malfunction but a structural condition. Addressing these biases is not only a technical challenge, but also a fundamentally political and epistemic issue that requires further critical inquiry. As an example in the context of hiring, simply anonymizing data by removing names and photos may not suffice, as other details, such as hobbies, previous jobs, and personal history, can still reveal stereotypical information about the individual. At the same time, processing sensitive attributes like gender may be crucial to effectively detect and mitigate diversity bias in data processing and AI design. These tensions are irresolvable through technical fixes alone.

5.2 | Theoretical and Practical Contributions

Theoretically, the findings demonstrate how various strands of feminist thought can converge to understand women's positions in relation to emerging AI systems. We agree with Toupin (2025) that no single feminist theory can offer a definitive solution to eliminating gender inequality as it appears in our data, and our findings confirm that the problem is both representational and structural. In line with Cordes (2020) and Wajcman and Young (2023), we argue that achieving these outcomes requires not only greater representation, but also a critical engagement with the structural forces that shape technology. Diversity interventions that add "representative faces" without changing the epistemological foundations of these systems are likely to produce exactly this pattern: marginal gains for those already closest to the norm, while structural disadvantage persists for those furthest from it.

Our positioning leads us to a stance of critical, rather than naive, optimism. By amplifying voices from those positioned at the intersections of multiple inequalities, and by critically examining the epistemic dimensions of AI, it may be possible to move toward technologies that benefit all genders. Yet, as Toupin (2025) and Lorde (2004) remind us, pursuing such goals within societies shaped by gender inequality and through technological systems that often reproduce them is far from

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straightforward. The risk is that reforms which focus on outcomes, such as fairness metrics, bias audits, and diverse hiring, leave intact the deeper epistemological structures that generate bias in the first place. Our research contributes to this ongoing effort by deepening understanding of gendered and intersectional perceptions and experiences of AI at work, offering insights for developers and policymakers alike. When individuals perceive AI tools as biased, distrust arises regardless of the system's actual fairness, undermining acceptance and legitimacy. Addressing gendered and intersectional perceptions of bias is, therefore, a critical step toward ensuring that technological innovation advances, rather than compromises, workplace equity.

5.3 | Strengths and Limitations

A major strength of this study lies in its broad cross-national scope, capturing the views of 4417 respondents across multiple European countries on one of the main challenges of our time, namely the integration of AI into workplace decision-making across the employment lifecycle, from job application to workplace exit. The large sample size, equal response among women and men, and geographic diversity provide a valuable empirical base for understanding emerging patterns of perception and experience related to AI-driven discrimination. However, several limitations must be acknowledged.

The sample is skewed toward younger individuals. While this may reflect greater interest in AI among younger employees and job seekers, it limits generalizability across age groups, particularly given the likelihood of generational differences in technological familiarity and trust. A more balanced age distribution would have strengthened the analysis, highlighting the need for future research.

While the study captures diverse perspectives within Europe, its geographic focus limits the generalizability of the findings to other global regions, where different socio-technical contexts and histories of discrimination may shape interactions with AI systems differently. Still, we believe that our findings have global relevance. As AI systems are increasingly implemented worldwide, mapping diverse perceptions and lived experiences, particularly in relation to discrimination, constitutes a crucial step toward developing context-sensitive and equitable governance frameworks. In addition, the study further shows important regional variations linked to the Global Gender Gap Index.

The survey design captured self-reported perceptions and experiences that, while valuable for capturing diverse and often underrepresented voices, are inevitably shaped by individual subjectivities. This approach allows for a more inclusive understanding of how various genders encounter and interpret AI systems in real-world settings, particularly in relation to discrimination. Simultaneously, it presents challenges, especially due to the technical complexity and opacity of many AI systems, which may affect respondents' ability to accurately identify or describe their interactions with such technologies. Accordingly, we do not assess participants' own understanding of AI or the specific AI tools they have used.

Gender categories reflect respondents' self-identification when the data was collected. However, the inability to statistically analyze the "other gender" category highlights the importance of complementing this self-reported data with future research, grounded in other methodological approaches. As the study lays the groundwork for future research by generating hypotheses for experimental or quasi-experimental methods, or by qualitative interviews, it provides new insights into how gender and intersecting axes of inequality shape attitudes toward AI, particularly in a field where empirical evidence is still limited.

6 | Conclusions

Our findings reveal persistent gender disparities in perception and experiences of AI-driven discrimination, highlighting how inclusion and exclusion are shaped in the intersection of AI with social hierarchies. The heightened concerns, especially amongst women, non-White individuals, and those in non-permanent employment, underscore the limits of purportedly neutral technologies developed and implemented without attention to social inequalities. Rather than mitigating bias, such systems risk reproducing and amplifying it.

Ensuring that AI advances gender equality requires moving beyond technical fixes toward explicitly intersectional and feminist approaches that address inequalities embedded in design, implementation, and governance. AI must be deliberately developed to reflect the diverse realities of its users, challenging the assumption of neutrality as the default. Although complex, this task is imperative. Confronting intersecting inequalities and engaging feminist perspectives that question whose knowledge, values, and experiences are embedded in technological systems are essential. Only then can AI contribute to workplaces that are genuinely trustworthy.

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Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available on request from the corresponding author. The data are not publicly available due to privacy or ethical restrictions.

Endnotes

[1] The GGGI by the World Economic Forum (2024) annually benchmarks the current state and evolution of gender parity across four key dimensions: Economic participation and opportunity, educational attainment, health and survival, and political empowerment

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(WEF, 2024). A total of 146 countries are included in the GGGI list. European countries occupy 7 of the top 10 places on the list, with Iceland ranked in the first place since 2009, having a score of 93.5% in 2024. The lowest scores among the European countries belong to Turkey (64.5%).

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Appendix A

TABLE A1 | Distribution of responses for sociodemographic factors among non-binary respondents.

Sociodemographic factor	*n*	%
Age		
18–28	89	61
29–39	30	21
40–50	13	9
> 50	14	10
Total	146	100
Race		
White	96	77
Non-White	28	23
Total	146	100
Education		
Tertiary education	84	63
Rest of educational levels	49	37
Total	146	100
Employment status		
Permanent employee	58	40
Non-permanent employee	88	60
Total	146	100
Global Gender Gap Index (GGGI)		
Above the median (Belgium, Denmark, Finland, France, Germany, Iceland, Ireland, Lithuania, Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, Spain, Sweden, and Switzerland)	91	62
Below the median (Austria, Bulgaria, Croatia, Czech Republic, Estonia, Greece, Italy, Luxembourg, Malta, Poland, Romania, Slovakia, Slovenia, and Turkey)	55	38
Total	146	100
Country of residence		
Poland	30	21
Portugal	21	14
Spain	15	10
Germany	12	8
Netherlands	11	8
France	10	7
Norway	8	5
Italy	6	4
Austria	5	3
Finland	4	3
Switzerland	4	3
Turkey	4	3
Slovenia	3	2
Belgium	2	1
Estonia	2	1
Greece	2	1
Ireland	2	1
Czech Republic	1	1
Sweden	1	1
Other European countries	3	2
Total	146	100

Note: This table displays the survey response distribution across categories for each sociodemographic factor included as predictors in the statistical models. Frequencies (*n*) and percentages (%) are shown for all analytical subgroups.

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